



PERFORMANCE SYSTEMS

Building a Performance Identity That Belongs to the System

How playing philosophy, local identity, physical preparation, nutrition and behaviour become one coherent performance system.

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Contents

Identity before method	3
Physical preparation must serve the game	4
The athlete does not experience departments	5
Behaviour is the integration point	6
Nutrition as professional practice	8
Evidence should sharpen judgement	9
Strategic leadership close to practice	10
Change, resistance and productive tension	11
Developing the department that develops the athlete	12
One identity with different expressions	13
From written philosophy to lived system	15
Evidence base	17



A physical performance strategy becomes meaningful only when it belongs to the environment it is intended to serve. It must be recognisable in the way the team wants to play, credible to the coaches who shape the week, relevant to the people who carry the identity and practical enough to influence what athletes repeatedly do. Everything else is documentation.

01

Identity before method

High performance sport has become very good at moving methods between environments. Programmes, technologies, testing batteries, staffing structures and language travel quickly, particularly when they are attached to a successful team. The risk is that organisations copy the visible product without understanding the conditions that allowed it to work.

A method can be evidence informed and still be wrong for the environment. It can be technically sophisticated while asking the wrong question, arriving at the wrong moment or ignoring the beliefs and behaviours that determine whether people will use it. The important starting point is therefore not which successful system should be imported. It is what this environment is trying to become, what it already carries and which physical and behavioural qualities will allow its athletes to express that ambition.

That requires an honest distinction between inherited identity, current reality and desired competitive identity. Inherited identity includes history, stories, regional influences, symbols, expectations and the qualities people believe belong to the shirt. Current reality includes the athletes who are actually available, the pathway that produced them, the resources around them and the habits that have become normal. Desired competitive identity describes how the organisation intends to be experienced by its opponents in the future. Treating these as the same thing creates nostalgia. Ignoring the first two in pursuit of the third creates an identity that looks convincing in a presentation but never feels true.

Research on social identity leadership supports the importance of leaders helping people experience a shared sense of who they are and what they are doing together. Longitudinal work in sport has linked identity leadership from coaches and athlete leaders with stronger team identification and related outcomes.¹ Work examining the use of Indigenous storytelling within a professional rugby environment also showed how culturally meaningful stories and symbols could strengthen identity, belonging, leadership and wellbeing.² These findings should not be reduced to the idea that every team needs a new slogan. Their practical meaning is that identity has to be carried through real relationships, shared interpretation and repeated behaviour.



The identity translation model

A performance identity is built by translating what the environment carries into what the team must repeatedly express.

Inherited identity History, place, stories, values and collective memory	Current reality People, resources, capability, habits and competitive position	Playing ambition How the team intends to solve the game and affect opponents
Performance demands Physical, technical, tactical, nutritional and psychological requirements	Daily behaviours What coaches, athletes and staff repeatedly reinforce	Competitive expression What becomes visible under pressure when choice narrows

The sequence matters. Starting with physical qualities and working backwards can produce an efficient training programme that has no distinct connection to the game. Starting with identity alone can produce emotional language without operational consequence. The work is to connect the two, preserving what is authentic while making clear choices about what must develop.

A genuine performance identity is not a description of what the organisation admires. It is a shared explanation of how its people intend to prepare, decide and act when the game becomes difficult.

02

Physical preparation must serve the game

Physical performance cannot sit beside the playing philosophy as a parallel body of work. Its purpose is to increase the number and quality of rugby actions the athlete can express, preserve those actions as fatigue and pressure accumulate and support the availability required to keep developing them.

This sounds self evident, yet misalignment is common. A coaching group may speak about speed, initiative and repeated pressure while the physical programme rewards volume without sufficient velocity or decision demand. The gym may develop impressive force qualities that are never connected to positions, moments or movement solutions on the field. Conditioning can become a separate test of character rather than preparation for the tactical problems the team is trying to create. Return to play can satisfy physical criteria without restoring confidence in the actions the game will demand.



The correction is not to make every physical session look like rugby. Physical qualities sometimes need concentrated development away from the complexity of the game. The correction is to make the purpose of that work traceable. Coaches and practitioners should be able to explain how a physical quality supports the playing model, where it is developed most effectively, how it is exposed under representative pressure and what evidence will show that it is transferring.

Ecological dynamics research is useful here because it treats skilled performance as an interaction between the athlete, the task and the environment rather than the reproduction of an ideal movement in isolation. Representative learning design asks whether practice preserves the information and action relationships that matter in competition.³ It does not remove the need for targeted strength, speed or power work. It strengthens the responsibility to connect those qualities to the situations in which athletes must perceive an opportunity, choose an action and coordinate with others.

OPERATIONAL TEST

Can the programme complete the sentence?

We are developing this quality because our playing philosophy asks this athlete to produce this action, in this context, with this frequency and under this level of physical and psychological pressure.

Alignment also changes planning conversations. Instead of physical staff receiving a completed rugby schedule and finding spaces within it, the week is co designed around the adaptation required. Technical coaches bring the tactical problem. Physical performance staff describe the cost and the adaptation opportunity. Medical staff clarify individual readiness and risk. Nutrition staff shape the fuel and recovery environment. Mental performance staff identify the attentional, emotional and behavioural demand. The final plan should feel like one week designed by one performance team.

When this works, the athlete encounters a coherent message. The language used in the gym supports the language on the field. Testing helps explain a rugby problem rather than creating a separate ranking system. Individual development remains visible inside collective preparation. When it fails, each discipline can still produce good work, but the combined effect is smaller because the athlete must resolve the contradictions.

03

The athlete does not experience departments

Organisations divide expertise into departments because specialisation matters. Athletes experience the combined environment. They do not experience a strategy chart.

An athlete who hears one message about body mass from a coach, another from a nutritionist and a third from a strength coach does not experience three professional opinions. They experience uncertainty. A player returning from injury who receives different definitions of readiness from medical, physical and technical staff does not experience multidisciplinary expertise. They experience a decision that nobody appears to own. A pathway athlete who is told to be creative on the field but is given no meaningful choice anywhere else in the programme experiences the culture more accurately than the values statement describes it.



A scoping review of interdisciplinary practice in performance sport found that collaboration is widely valued but remains inconsistently defined and evidenced.⁴ Earlier integrated performance health models also challenged reductionist service structures in which specialists operate separately and leave athletes or coaches to reconcile the recommendations.⁵ The practical issue is not whether an organisation has the right disciplines. It is whether those disciplines create shared decisions.

Shared decisions require more than friendliness. They require a common performance question, clarity about who contributes what, permission to challenge assumptions and an agreed point of accountability. They also require enough protected time for genuine integration. Without it, multidisciplinary work becomes a sequence of updates, each discipline reporting what it has done while the connections remain implicit.

One athlete, one environment

Each specialist contributes a different lens while decisions remain organised around the same athlete and playing problem.

Playing intent	Athlete state	Integrated action	Shared review
The rugby problem and desired competitive expression	Readiness, health, capability, history and development need	Training, nutrition, recovery, behaviour and support	What changed, what transferred and what requires adjustment

The strongest performance teams develop a shared mental model without demanding identical thinking. Research and applied case studies in invasion sports suggest that shared mental models can support collective decision making and coordination.⁶ The useful tension is that alignment should create a common frame while preserving the different perspectives that make expert teams valuable. Agreement on purpose must not become pressure to agree on every interpretation.

This is why psychological safety has a performance function as well as a wellbeing function. It is not comfort or the avoidance of standards. It is the capacity to raise uncertainty, challenge a decision, acknowledge an error and offer information before the cost of silence becomes greater. Sport specific research has linked athlete voice and the capacity to manage conflict with stronger coach and athlete relationships.⁷ A team that cannot disagree constructively will eventually protect harmony at the expense of judgement.

04

Behaviour is the integration point

Physical performance, nutrition and mental performance are often described as separate areas because they draw on different professional knowledge. In the athlete's day they repeatedly meet at the level of behaviour.

The athlete has to arrive prepared, engage with intent, regulate effort, tolerate discomfort, ask for help, interpret feedback, make decisions while fatigued, recover with discipline and repeat the process across a long season. These are neither purely physical nor purely psychological acts. They are behaviours shaped by capability, motivation, opportunity, relationships and the design of the environment.



Mental performance integration is therefore not achieved by adding a workshop to the calendar. It begins when the performance group agrees on the behaviours the playing philosophy requires and then deliberately creates opportunities to practise them. If the game model depends on players scanning early and making assertive decisions, the training environment has to develop perception, confidence, communication and responsibility alongside the physical ability to arrive in position. If the team wants composure after error, the review process cannot punish honest reflection. If adaptability matters, athletes need enough autonomy to make and learn from meaningful choices.

There is an important distinction between demanding a behaviour and developing the capacity behind it. Telling an athlete to be resilient may describe the desired response without addressing the skill, support or exposure required. Calling for ownership while every significant decision remains controlled by staff creates the same contradiction. Behaviour is more likely to become reliable when expectations are clear, practice is representative, feedback is useful and the surrounding system makes the preferred action possible.

The behaviour integration loop

Behaviour becomes more reliable when the whole environment reinforces the same capability.

Name the behaviour Describe what it looks like in a real performance moment	Explain its purpose Connect it to the playing identity and athlete's role	Design the exposure Create physical, tactical and emotional conditions to practise it
Coach the response Use shared language and feedback across disciplines	Reflect with honesty Review decisions and context rather than only outcomes	Reinforce over time Align selection, recognition, leadership and daily routines

Mental fatigue research provides one reminder that cognitive and physical performance are not cleanly separated. Experimental work has shown that mental fatigue can reduce exercise tolerance through an increased perception of effort.⁸ The broader application is not that every mental demand must be minimised. Competition will not offer that protection. It is that cognitive and emotional load should be understood, planned and trained with the same care given to physical load.

Integration becomes visible in ordinary moments. It appears in how a coach responds when a player questions a plan, how staff discuss body composition, whether leaders admit uncertainty, how mistakes are reviewed and whether the pressure built into practice has a clear developmental purpose. A mental performance philosophy that exists only in the psychologist's room cannot consistently influence those moments.



Nutrition as professional practice

Nutrition is frequently treated as a knowledge problem. In most established performance environments, athletes already know that food, fluid and recovery matter. The harder problem is translating knowledge into choices that survive travel, fatigue, appetite, family life, cultural preference, limited time, changing body goals and the social influence of the group.

Expert statements in elite football provide detailed guidance across match preparation, recovery, body composition, supplementation and common travel demands.⁹ The existence of guidance does not guarantee implementation. A systematic review of sports nutrition interventions found limited and inconsistent use of established behaviour change techniques, highlighting the gap between providing information and changing dietary behaviour.¹⁰ More recent research with professional football practitioners has also identified the social environment, practitioner autonomy, confidence and organisational support as important influences on whether consensus guidance is applied.¹¹

This makes nutrition a leadership and environment design responsibility as well as a specialist service. The strategy has to connect nutrition with the playing and physical demands, make the desired choices available and normal, account for the athlete population and progressively build the judgement required when direct support is absent.

Athlete ownership does not mean leaving athletes alone with more information. It means helping them understand the purpose, develop practical skills, participate in setting relevant goals and evaluate the effects of their choices. It also means recognising that the same message will not land equally across age, sex, culture, socioeconomic background, training age or living situation. Uniform standards can coexist with individual routes towards them.

FROM INFORMATION TO OWNERSHIP

A practical nutrition progression

Make the performance demand clear. Shape the environment so the preferred action is easier. Teach skills in the context where they will be used. Give the athlete increasing responsibility. Use feedback that connects choices with energy, recovery, availability and performance. Review without moral judgement.

A professional nutrition culture is also visible in the language around food and bodies. Messages must support performance and health without creating shame or rewarding harmful compliance. The same psychological safety expected in injury reporting should extend to discussions about eating behaviour, body composition and supplementation. This becomes particularly important across men's and women's programmes where energy availability, hormonal health, development history and social pressure may require different expertise and different conversations within a shared organisational philosophy.

When nutrition is central, it is present in planning rather than added after it. The nutrition lead understands the training week early enough to influence provision and education. Coaches reinforce the strategy accurately. Performance staff recognise how physical targets interact with fuelling. Leaders fund the food environment as part of performance delivery. Athletes can explain not only what they are doing but why it matters for their role and current phase of development.



Evidence should sharpen judgement

Data is most useful when it changes the quality of a decision. The volume of information collected matters far less than the organisation's ability to interpret it in context, communicate uncertainty and act at the right time.

Testing can establish physical profiles, identify meaningful gaps, guide individual development and show whether a programme is producing the adaptation it claims. Monitoring can contribute to decisions about readiness and help staff notice change before it becomes obvious. Neither can replace the coach's understanding of the player, the athlete's account of their own state or the contextual knowledge held across the performance team.

The false choice between data and intuition is unhelpful. Intuition is often compressed experience, but it is also vulnerable to bias, recent events and the influence of status. Data can discipline judgement, but it is also shaped by what was measured, how reliably it was collected and which questions the analyst chose to ask. Good systems allow each to challenge the other.

Work on decision making in professional sport has argued for cultures that use diverse perspectives, deliberate approaches to common biases and evaluation systems with rigorous feedback.¹² That combination matters because the aim is not to produce certainty where certainty does not exist. It is to improve the probability of a sound decision and make the reasoning visible enough to review.

The evidence to action filter

Before a measure enters the system, it should survive six practical questions.

Question	What it protects
What decision could this change?	Collection without purpose
Is the measure reliable enough for that decision?	False precision
What context could alter the interpretation?	Numbers detached from the athlete
Who needs the information and in what form?	Reports that do not travel
What action follows each plausible result?	Monitoring without response
When will we review whether it helped?	Systems that accumulate without learning

Possibility focused leadership uses evidence to open options. A slower than expected speed exposure may invite questions about programme design, role demand, confidence, pain, opportunity or technical efficiency. It should not automatically reduce the athlete to a colour on a dashboard. Measurement is most powerful when it produces a better conversation and a more precise next action.



Strategic leadership close to practice

The leader of a performance system has to work at two distances. They need enough separation from daily delivery to see patterns, align resources, develop people and make decisions for the whole system. They also need enough contact with practice to know whether the strategy survives the training ground.

Too much distance creates elegant plans that underestimate delivery. Too much immersion allows urgent operational work to consume the time required for system leadership. The solution is not an even split of hours. It is deliberate movement between the balcony and the floor, with clarity about which decisions require each perspective.

Being hands on can provide credibility, reveal friction and allow the leader to support critical moments. It becomes a problem when it turns into permanent rescue, bypasses the practitioners responsible for delivery or keeps the leader attached to the identity of being the most technically capable person in the room. The highest value of senior expertise is often not the session delivered personally but the capability created around it.

Recent work exploring the role of high performance managers in professional team sport identified themes including athlete development, programme execution, standards, integration, leadership, strategic alignment and helping others succeed.¹³ That breadth reflects the reality that the role is not simply a more senior version of a strength and conditioning coach. It is responsible for the conditions in which multiple experts can make good decisions together.

Presence is also misunderstood. It is not volume, certainty or the need to dominate every room. Presence is the ability to make the purpose clear, hold a standard when pressure encourages compromise, listen without surrendering responsibility and say what the moment requires in language the audience can use. The head coach may need the competitive consequence. The practitioner may need the operating principle. The athlete may need a clear personal reason and one practical action. Strategic communication preserves the meaning while changing the entry point.

Credibility is not earned only by knowing the work. At senior level it is earned by connecting the work, improving the people who deliver it and remaining accountable when the system is tested.



Change, resistance and productive tension

Meaningful change creates loss as well as possibility. People may lose familiar routines, status, autonomy, certainty or a version of the organisation in which their expertise was easier to recognise. Early resistance is therefore not automatic proof that the direction is wrong.

Leaders still need to diagnose resistance accurately. Some resistance reveals a real flaw in the plan. Some reflects previous change efforts that were announced and abandoned. Some protects local knowledge that the strategy has failed to include. Some is an understandable response to poor timing or insufficient capacity. Some is a direct challenge to higher standards because the current system rewards avoidance. Treating every objection as negativity is as weak as allowing every objection to stop the work.

Direct conversations become necessary when behaviour and intent separate. The purpose is not confrontation for its own sake. It is to make the gap visible, understand what is driving it and establish what must happen next. Strong leaders can remain respectful without making the message ambiguous. They can also accept that being understood is not the same as being liked.

Psychological safety is particularly relevant during change, but it should never be used to remove accountability. Research in elite sport describes psychological safety through organisational conditions, leadership behaviour and cultural norms that allow people to seek support and speak honestly.¹⁴ In a performance system, safety and challenge should strengthen each other. People need enough safety to raise the difficult issue and enough shared commitment to act once it is raised.

The resistance diagnosis

The response should match what the resistance is protecting.

What may sit underneath	Leadership response
Missing context	Explain the purpose, consequence and decision path
Excluded expertise	Bring local knowledge into design without surrendering direction
Limited capability	Teach, rehearse, support and stage the demand
Change fatigue	Narrow the priorities and produce visible early proof
Misaligned incentive	Change what is rewarded, tolerated and reviewed
Refusal of the standard	Use a clear direct conversation and follow through

Change is sustained through cadence more than announcement. People need to see the strategy reflected in calendars, decisions, staffing, feedback, resource allocation and what leaders continue to ask about after the launch has passed. A system learns to distrust priorities that disappear when competition becomes difficult. Staying the course does not mean defending every original detail. It means preserving the purpose while adjusting the route in response to evidence.



Developing the department that develops the athlete

An organisation cannot build an adaptable athlete pathway through a department that does not learn. Practitioner development is therefore not an internal benefit sitting behind performance delivery. It is one of the mechanisms through which the quality of delivery improves.

Upskilling begins with role clarity. Practitioners need to understand what good looks like in their current role, which decisions they own, how their work connects to the wider strategy and what capability will be required next. Development should combine technical growth with communication, judgement, leadership and the ability to work across disciplines. A technically strong practitioner who cannot translate their thinking or collaborate under pressure will eventually limit the system.

Leaders also need the humility to recognise where the department lacks expertise. Bringing in external knowledge is not an admission of weakness when the purpose is clear and internal capability is developed through the process. It becomes wasteful when outside experts deliver isolated content that the local team cannot absorb, apply or sustain. Specialist support should answer a defined performance question, connect with the operating model and leave the system more capable than it found it.

Interdisciplinary leadership research has argued that contemporary performance and health teams require leadership that can protect athlete health, preserve availability and coordinate people with different professional backgrounds.¹⁵ This coordination depends on structures such as shared planning, case discussion, decision rights, review cycles and feedback. Culture matters, but culture without operating structure relies too heavily on personal relationships and becomes fragile when people change.

There are also times when development is not enough. A role may no longer fit the direction, a capability gap may be too large for the available timeframe or repeated behaviour may remain inconsistent with the required standard despite clear support. Reshaping a department is sometimes part of responsible leadership. The fairness of that process depends on whether expectations were explicit, feedback was honest, support was real and decisions were made for the needs of the system rather than personal preference.

DEPARTMENT HEALTH

Four questions worth returning to

Do our people understand the strategy? Can they translate it into their own work? Do our structures allow them to collaborate and decide well? Are we developing the capability the future system will require rather than only maintaining today's delivery?



One identity with different expressions

A national philosophy should create connection across senior men's, senior women's and pathway programmes without pretending they are the same environment. Consistency of principle does not require uniformity of delivery.

Programmes may sit at different stages of staffing, resourcing, athlete training age, professional exposure and competitive maturity. The athlete populations may require distinct expertise and different practical support. A central strategy that ignores those differences can widen inequity while claiming consistency. A completely local approach can create fragmentation and leave athletes relearning the system at every transition.

The useful middle is a small number of shared principles with clearly defined room for local expression. The organisation may agree on how physical qualities connect to playing intent, how athlete health is protected, how information is shared, how nutrition ownership develops and how people are treated. Each programme can then determine the methods, sequence and language that best fit its athletes and stage of development.

Pathway work must also resist the temptation to turn the senior programme into a smaller age group copy. Developing athletes need age appropriate physical foundations, broad movement capability, sound nutrition habits and environments that maintain curiosity and belonging. The pathway should prepare them for future performance demands without asking them to live like established senior professionals before their context supports it.

This requires a clear transition architecture. Athletes and staff should know which capabilities become increasingly important, what information follows the athlete, how support changes at key transitions and where local coaches contribute to national understanding. Shared standards can make those transitions more coherent, but relationships carry the information that standards cannot.

Consistent principles, contextual delivery

The centre owns the common intent and quality threshold. Each programme shapes the expression with its athletes and coaches.

Held in common	Adapted locally
Performance philosophy and connection to playing intent	Programme methods, session design and progression
Core athlete health and professional standards	Support model for sex, age, culture and training history
Shared language for key physical and behavioural qualities	Examples, stories and coaching cues that carry local meaning
Minimum information and transition requirements	Technology, staffing and meeting cadence appropriate to context
Commitment to evidence, review and learning	Measures that answer the programme's current questions



A national system becomes visible when athletes experience greater continuity as they move, practitioners can contribute beyond their immediate programme and senior learning returns to the pathway rather than remaining at the top. Cascade should never mean instructions travelling downwards only. Strong systems create movement in both directions.



From written philosophy to lived system

The value of a philosophy is not found in how complete it sounds. It is found in the decisions it helps people make when the leader is not in the room.

Implementation begins with diagnosis. Before changing structures or methods, leaders need to understand the competitive ambition, coaching philosophy, athlete population, staff capability, resource reality, decision pathways and history of previous change. This is not a passive listening period. It is disciplined inquiry designed to identify the few issues that will most affect the system.

The next task is alignment. The performance philosophy must be tested with coaching, medical, nutrition, mental performance and pathway leaders until the language is shared and the practical consequences are understood. Alignment does not mean every person writes the strategy together or retains a veto. It means the important interfaces have been considered and people understand how their work contributes.

Early action should produce proof without pretending the whole system can change at once. Useful early wins often improve clarity: a more coherent planning rhythm, agreed decision rights, a simplified monitoring response, one integrated athlete meeting, a clearly defined physical quality connected to playing intent or a nutrition process that removes an obvious barrier. These actions matter because they show what the philosophy looks like in practice.

Capability then has to grow around the new expectations. Staff need support, athletes need repeated explanation and the organisation may need to adjust roles, resources or external expertise. Measurement should include outcomes, process quality and the experience of the people using the system. Performance results matter, but they are too noisy and too delayed to be the only evidence of progress.

The five movements of implementation

The work is iterative. Each movement informs the next and sends new information back through the system.

Diagnose Understand identity, ambition, people, constraints and decision flow	Align Connect coaching, performance, health, nutrition and behaviour flow	Prove Create early actions that make the philosophy tangible
Build Develop people, structures, tools and specialist capability	Embed Reinforce through cadence, accountability and resource decisions	Learn Review evidence, preserve purpose and adjust the route

There will always be pressure to move faster. National programmes operate within selection cycles, campaigns, leadership changes and public expectation. Urgency is real, but speed without sequence creates rework. The aim is to move with enough pace that people feel progress and enough discipline that progress can hold.

The strongest sign of maturity is not that every programme looks identical. It is that people can explain the same performance intent, make contextually sound decisions and recognise when local flexibility has drifted beyond the shared standard. The system becomes coherent without becoming rigid.



Physical performance and nutrition can then occupy their proper place. They are not support functions waiting to be included and they are not independent authorities trying to control the programme. They are part of how the organisation expresses its rugby identity, develops its people and prepares athletes to make effective decisions under the demands of the game.

The work is complete only when the identity can be felt in the week, seen in the behaviour and recognised in the way the team performs when the plan is under pressure.



Evidence base

The research below informs the article's argument. It is used as support for applied judgement rather than as a claim that any single study can prescribe an entire performance system.

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About the author

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